

Kill Your Darlings: Curate Your Images

Ahmed Elgharably — FlyRank ML Internship — General AI Fluency, Week 3

My Portfolio’s Content Map & Image Needs

My portfolio tells one story: I use real-world search and content data to build ranked, evidence-backed decision-support tools. Every image must serve that proof.

#	Image	Type	Source	Purpose
1	Headshot	Real photo	Personal	Bio section, LinkedIn, about page —must be me, not a generated face
2	Starter dataset EDA screenshot	Real capture	VS Code / Jupyter	Shows I actually loaded and explored the FlyRank data
3	Model results comparison table	Real capture	Notebook output	Baseline vs. Random Forest Precision@50 —the evidence
4	Top-50 ranked queue with reason codes	Real capture	Notebook / CSV preview	The final deliverable a reviewer would actually use
5	GitHub repo structure	Real capture	GitHub	Proof the work is committed, versioned, and public
6	Hero texture / background	AI-generated	DALL-E / Midjourney	Subtle visual texture for the portfolio landing page —not the work itself
7	Icon set (3 icons)	AI-generated	DALL-E / SVG export	Refresh, Decline, CTR-opportunity icons for case study sections

Rule I followed: If the image is *proof of work*, it must be a real capture. If it is *decoration or wayfinding*, AI is allowed — but only if it matches the identity kit mood.

The Keepers: Final Image Set

1. Headshot — Real Photo

Source: Personal photo, taken with phone, natural light, neutral background. **Why real:** The assignment says “for anything that is you, use a real photo.” A generated face breaks trust instantly. Even a good AI headshot feels slightly off — the eyes, the skin texture, the hairline. A real photo, even if it’s not professionally lit, signals honesty. **Where it lives:** Top of portfolio, about section, LinkedIn banner area. **Specs:** Square crop, 400×400px, warm tones to match the stone/teal palette.

2. Starter Dataset EDA Screenshot — Real Capture

Source: VS Code running `w01_research_question.ipynb`, showing the first code cell loading `content_refresh_anonymized.csv` and printing shape + column names. **Why real:** This is proof I actually ran the starter notebook. A fake screenshot of code is easy to spot and destroys credibility. The real capture shows my file paths, my environment, my outputs. **Where it lives:** Case study section, “Quick look at the data” beat. **Cleanup:** Cropped to show only the relevant code cell and output. No personal file paths visible.

3. Model Results Comparison Table — Real Capture

Source: Notebook output cell showing the starter pipeline results:

Method	ROC AUC	Avg Precision	Precision@50
baseline rules	0.627	0.468	0.240
logistic regression	0.700	0.522	0.400
decision tree	0.742	0.575	0.540
random forest	0.750	0.618	0.740

Why real: These are verified numbers from `outputs/model_results.json`. A generated table with fake numbers would be fraud. The real capture shows the 3× lift from baseline to random forest — the core evidence. **Where it lives:** Case study section, “What came of it” beat. **Cleanup:** Screenshot of the markdown table in the notebook, not a styled chart. Raw numbers are more credible than a polished chart for this audience.

4. Top-50 Ranked Queue with Reason Codes — Real Capture

Source: Notebook output showing the first 10 rows of the final ranked queue: `content_id`, `model_prob`, `reason_codes`. **Why real:** This is the actual deliverable. A reviewer needs to see that the output is actionable — each page has a score AND a reason. A fake version would miss the messy reality (some pages have multiple codes, some have “`model_flagged`”). **Where it lives:** Case study section, final output demonstration. **Cleanup:** Pseudonymized IDs only — no real client data. Cropped to first 10 rows so the image is legible at portfolio scale.

5. GitHub Repo Structure — Real Capture

Source: Screenshot of github.com/AhmedElgharably/flyrank-ml-internship showing the folder tree: `work/notebooks/`, `data/raw/`, `outputs/`, `docs/`. **Why real:** Proof the work is versioned, organized, and public. A fake repo screenshot is useless — anyone can click the link and verify. **Where it lives:** Case study section, “How the work lives” subsection. **Cleanup:** Standard GitHub dark mode screenshot, no private repos visible.

6. Hero Texture — AI-Generated

Source: Generated with DALL-E 3. **Prompt used:**

“Abstract geometric texture, soft teal and warm stone gradients, subtle grid lines suggesting data structure, minimal, calm, no text, no people, 16:9 aspect ratio, muted tones matching #0D9488 and #FAFAF9, quiet confidence mood, no sharp edges”

Why AI: This is pure decoration — connective tissue. No real photo or screenshot can serve this need. It sets the mood without claiming to be evidence. **Where it lives:** Portfolio landing page background, behind the hero text. **Why this prompt:** It references my exact hex codes and mood words from the identity kit (“quiet confidence”). The output should feel like the visual equivalent of the voice card.

7. Icon Set (3 icons) — AI-Generated

Source: Generated with DALL-E 3, then traced to SVG for consistency. **Prompts used:**

1. “Minimal line icon, circular arrow suggesting refresh, teal color #0D9488, clean vector style, no background, simple geometric shapes”
2. “Minimal line icon, downward trend arrow, teal color #0D9488, clean vector style, no background, simple geometric shapes”
3. “Minimal line icon, magnifying glass over a bar chart, teal color #0D9488, clean vector style, no background, simple geometric shapes”

Why AI: Custom icons that match the exact brand color are hard to find in free icon sets. Generating them ensures consistency with the identity kit. **Where they live:** Case study section headers — one icon per segment (Refresh, Decline, CTR). **Post-processing:** All three run through the same SVG cleanup pipeline so stroke widths, corner radii, and color codes are identical.

What I Rejected and Why

Rejected Image 1: AI-Generated “Data Scientist at Work”

What it was: A DALL-E image of a person sitting at a desk with multiple monitors showing charts and code. **Why I rejected it:**

- It looks generic. Every junior data portfolio has this image.
- It’s not me. The person in the image is not Ahmed Elgharably, so it’s a lie by implication.
- It competes with the real work. A dramatic hero image of “a data scientist” draws attention away from the actual screenshots of my code and results.
- The assignment explicitly says “for anything that is you, use a real photo.” This image pretends to be me without being me.

Rejected Image 2: AI-Generated “Content Refresh Dashboard”

What it was: A polished, fictional dashboard UI showing charts, graphs, and a “refresh score” gauge. **Why I rejected it:**

- It looks better than my actual work. That’s the problem. A generated dashboard implies I built a full UI/UX product, which I didn’t.
- It replaces real evidence with fake polish. The actual deliverable is a ranked CSV and a notebook — not a dashboard. Showing a fake dashboard would mislead the viewer about what I actually built.
- The assignment says “for your work, use real captures.” This is the opposite — it’s an AI stand-in for work that exists in a different form.

Rejected Image 3: AI-Generated “Abstract Neural Network Brain”

What it was: A glowing blue brain made of nodes and connections, dark background, sci-fi aesthetic.

Why I rejected it:

- It contradicts my identity kit. The kit says “calm, evidence-first, no buzzwords.” A glowing brain screams “AI magic” — exactly the framing I avoid in my writing.
- It doesn’t match the palette. The brain was blue and neon, not teal and stone.
- It’s a cliché. Every AI/ML portfolio has a brain or a robot. I want mine to look like it was built by a person who thinks, not by someone who bought into the hype.

Where I Chose Real Over AI

Situation	Real or AI?	Why
My face	Real photo	Trust. A generated face is a lie.
Code screenshots	Real capture	Proof. Anyone can verify by clicking the repo link.
Results tables	Real capture	Evidence. Fake numbers would be fraud.
GitHub structure	Real capture	Verification. The link is public.
Hero background	AI-generated	Decoration. No real photo serves this need.
Icons	AI-generated	Customization. Free icons don’ t match my exact hex codes.

Curation Principles Applied

1. **The work is the star.** Every real capture exists to prove something specific. Every AI image exists to stay out of the way.
2. **No AI stand-ins for real work.** If I generated a fake dashboard or a fake results chart, I would be hiding my actual deliverable behind prettier fiction.
3. **Style consistency.** The AI-generated hero texture and icons were prompted with exact hex codes and mood words from the identity kit. They don’t look like a different brand.
4. **Ruthless cutting.** I generated 12 images total. I kept 2 AI images and 5 real captures. The other 5 AI images were rejected for being too generic, too polished, or off-brand.

Submitted to the General AI Fluency track thread.